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The Fruit of Knowledge and the Bodies of the Gods: Religious Meanings of Plants among the Baniwa

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Abstract

This article focuses on the sacrificial acts of divinities and other primal beings whose bodies became cultivated, and wild plants, particularly plants as forms of gifts and other types of exchange from the deities to humanity among the Baniwa peoples of the Northwest Amazon. I seek to reflect on Viveiros de Castro's ideas on Amerindian 'perspectivism' (1998, 2002) to evaluate their 'fit' to Baniwa spiritual ethnobotany. Initially, I see a major difference between the perspectivism and agentivity of animal and fish-people, which is very common among all Arawak and Tukanoan-speaking peoples, and the plants which derive more often from a divinity that has been sacrificed, dismembered, transformed, and divided up into many distinct species. The predator–prey relation between animals, fish, and humans is actually secondary when compared to sacrifice and gifting relations between plants and humans, which seem to have more to do with the peaceful development of chiefly and priestly societies.

Introduction

In the Northwest Amazon region, bordering Brazil, Venezuela, and Colombia, the Arawak-speaking Baniwa people (pop. approx. 12,000) have developed a highly refined conceptual system for understanding and managing their animal and plant resources. The Baniwa live basically from horticulture, specializing in manioc, fishing, and, to a much lesser degree, hunting. They have also experienced a long history of contact involving them in various kinds of salaried labor for non-indigenous peoples, primarily those of European heritage.[1]

1. On the history of contact, see Wright 1981, 1998, 2005.

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Their stories of the creation time (*oopidali*, ancient times) illustrate how the deities struggled to eke out a niche for themselves in a world dominated by predatory animal tribes. In large part, the critical issue for the creator deities was how to make the world safe from predatory animals and fish so that humans could not only live within it but also be prosperous and enjoy well-being. The world the deities left for their descendants (*walimanai*, lit., 'our others who will be born') was far from perfect, however; but at least the deities left the instruments by which humans could not only protect themselves from predators but also obtain their food from various domains and by various means.

This article will discuss the following topics in order: (1) the sacred plants introduced in mythical times and their religious and cultural importance; (2) the major cycles of creation epochs which produced the cosmos as it is known today; (3) the shaman's psychoactive *pariká*, the most important agent of creation, and the narratives that shamans tell of how they acquired their powers; (4) the shaman's experience 'on *pariká*' of being 'taught' how the world is; (5) narratives of how the earth was made for gardens, how tobacco was given to humanity, and how the divine 'owner of gardens' sacrificed himself in a new garden-fire to alleviate the hunger of his children; and (6) concluding remarks linking the themes of divine sacrifice, the gift of knowledge and power, and Amerindian perspectivism.

Plants of Creation and Destruction

Given that the food chain is a critical issue in many stories of creation of the Northwest Amazon, it has long been studied by anthropologists.[2] These studies have generally focused on the 'predator–prey' exchange relations among humans, animals, and fish.[3] Unlike their Tukanoan-speaking neighbors, for whom the anthropological literature is far richer in scope (Arhem 2001; Hugh-Jones 1979; Reichel-Dolmatoff 1968, 1975), for the Baniwa/Kuripako/Wakuenai,[4] there is one book-length study on

2. On the Brazilian side of the border, the indigenous population is more than 30,000 people, or 22 ethnic groups, pertaining to 3 major language families—Tukano, Arawak, and Maku.

3. K. Arhem (2001) gives an in-depth description of the interconnection between humans and nature in his ethnography of the Makuna, Tukanoan-speaking people on the border of Colombia and Brazil.

4. The three names refer to three groups who consider themselves kin to one another, who speak dialects of the same Arawak language, and make their villages on three sides of the Brazil/Venezuela/Colombia border. The present paper is concerned with the Baniwa of the Aiary River in Brazil.

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Baniwa horticulture (Journet 1995), one article on shamans' snuff, *pariká* (Wright 2005), Wakuenai symbolic ecology (Hill 1984), and stories related to water-spirits and fish (Garnelo 2007; Wright 1993–94). There have been *no studies that have systematically examined the nexus of symbolic meanings related to plants and their religious significance for human life.* This article seeks to provide at least an introduction to this field by selecting several of the culturally most significant plants.

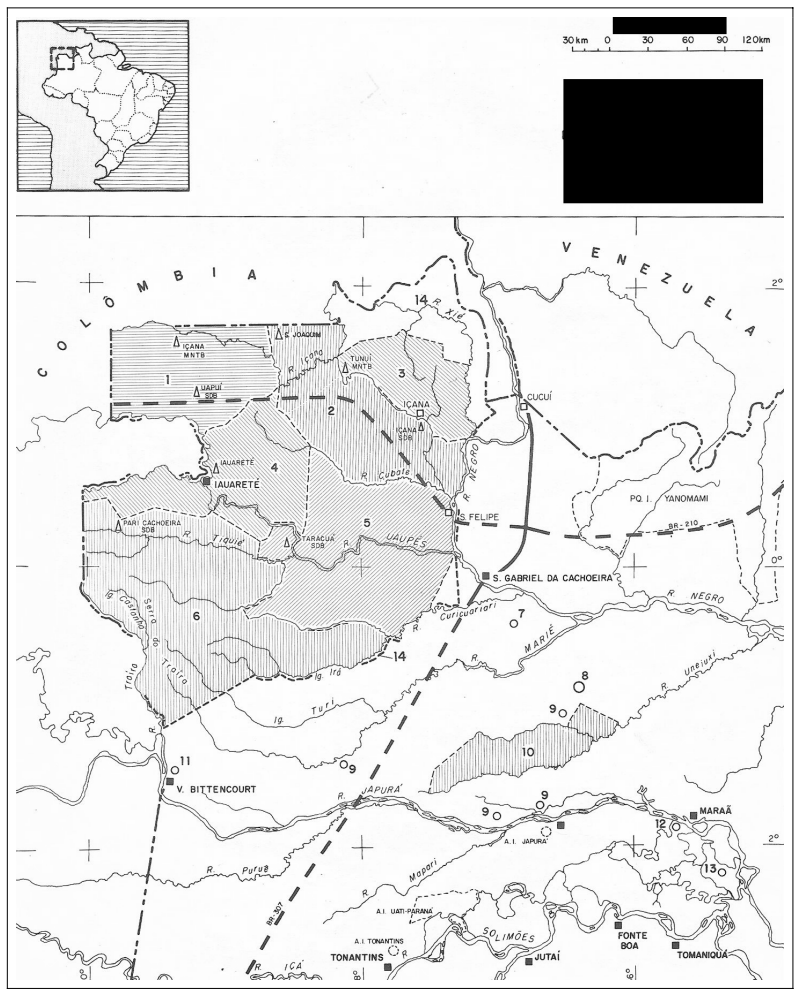


Figure 1. The Northwest Amazon

In Baniwa stories of creation, the trees from which the psychoactive *pariká* (*Virola calophylla*, *Virola theiodora*, *Anadenanthera peregrina*), or

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shamans' snuff, is produced are perhaps the most important of all the plants since it was only through the visions propitiated by the snuff that the creator deity could 'see the world and everything in it'.[5] In the wrong hands, as the story tells, *pariká* transformed a gluttonous and selfish tapir into a predatory jaguar and made other animals who snuffed the powder go mad.

Tobacco and pepper are two other plants of major importance in the creation stories. The first is essential for 'bringing the souls [of humans] back' from wherever they have wandered (in sickness or dreams). The second is an essential element of commensality because, according to its mythic origin, it prevents food (fish and animals) from giving sickness to humans by annulling the sickness-giving potential of both fish and animals on humans. Both pepper and tobacco were also among the gifts of the deities to humanity. At the time the first ancestors emerged from the hole in the rocks at *Hipana* waterfalls, each clan was given its own riverine territory, ancestral flute or trumpet, stock of ancestral names, and kinds of sacred pepper and tobacco.

Manioc is the fourth plant; it is a staple food, but its religious importance is that it is also the 'body' of the deity *Kaali*, who sacrificed himself in a great fire in order to provide food for his children. His 'body' became food for humans, in the form of manioc bread, which, like pepper and tobacco, are the staple of life. This cannot be described as a predatory relation, but rather a sacrificial 'gift' of the deity's body *and* knowledge of planting to humanity.

Finally, there are the poisonous plants—timbó, for example, used in fishing; curare, for hunting; and numerous plants used in witchcraft and sorcery as well as in their cure. These were generated from the bodies of slain primordial beings who left their viscera, fluids, or body-parts which transformed into these plants in retribution for their killing, or the killing of one of their kin. They clearly serve humans today as tools of predation. This paper discusses above all the nexus of 'exchange' and

5. The original *pariká* came from the fruits of the 'Great Tree of *Kaali*' (*Kaali ka thidzapa*), a huge tree that was the source of all cultivated plants. The Great Tree of *Kaali* is one of the central symbols of primordial unity, or All-in-Oneness that is found in Baniwa religion. The Tree is said to have been located at Uaracapory Falls on the Uaupés River, to the Northwest of where the Baniwa live today. In the early twentieth century, the famous German ethnologist Theodor Koch-Grünberg, during his travels throughout the Northwest Amazon, noted the great number of place-names on the upper Uaupés that were Arawak and related to Baniwa mythology, indicating that this area had been populated by Baniwa. Early mid-eighteenth century maps corroborate this (Wright 1981).

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'predatory' relations involving plants which are essential for the creation and reproduction of society.

The order in which the plants will be considered here follows the order of creation stories according to Baniwa narrators of the villages where I have done most of my field research, Uapui or *Hipana* and Ukuki (see map above).[6] It does not reflect a 'definitive' ordering of the narratives; although, in comparing among narrators of several other villages, there appears to be agreement on which of the narratives are, as Baniwa narrators say, 'the really important ones' which happened first. In 1999, the indigenous association of the area, I, and several of the narrators published a volume of these narratives under the title *Waferinaipe Ianheke: The Wisdom of our Ancestors*.[7]

Religious Lives of Baniwa in Brazil

The religious lives of the Arawak-speaking Baniwa and Kuripako or Wakuenai[8] of the Brazil/Venezuela/Colombia borders are, like their Tukanoan-speaking neighbors, based on great mythological and ritual cycles related to the first ancestors and symbolized by the sacred flutes and trumpets, as well as the central importance of shamanism and a rich variety of dance rituals, called *pudali*, associated with the seasonal cycles and the maturation of forest fruits. In the 1950s, the majority of the Baniwa converted to evangelical Protestantism, introduced by missionaries of the New Tribes Mission. Their mass conversion was historically continuous with their participation in prophetic movements since the mid-nineteenth century; however, evangelicalism provoked a radical break from their shamanic traditions, as well as serious divisions and conflicts with Catholic Baniwa and those who sought to maintain Catholic-based ritual traditions. Today, after half-a-century, evangelicalism is now the predominant religion in over half the Baniwa

6. My doctoral research was done in 1976–77; brief periods of fieldwork were done in 1986, 1997, 2000–2002. Since 2005, I have been in internet and telephone contact with the children of my main interlocutors of my first field research.

7. This was volume 3 of the series 'Indigenous Narrators of the Rio Negro' (Federation of the Indigenous Organizations of the Rio Negro, São Gabriel da Cachoeira, AM, Brazil).

8. '*Wakuenai*' and '*Walimanai*' are the two ethnonyms used by the people to refer to all interrelated phratries on all three sides of the borders. *Wakuenai* means 'All those of our language', and *Walimanai* means 'All our descendants'. Since colonial times, 'Baniwa'—which is not originally an ethnonym—has been used by outsiders to the extent that it has become one, like 'Kuripako' which refers to a dialect-group among the four extant today.

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communities, although there is a growing movement among non-evangelicals and some evangelical communities to revitalize the initiation rituals and mythic traditions.

In the history of the cosmos, according to both evangelical and non-evangelical Baniwa, there have been various moments when the world was destroyed and later regenerated. The Baniwa diverge on the nature of the first world: evangelical Baniwa believe that only one Being, *Heeko*, existed at that time; shamans refer to that time as an 'ancient, hidden world of happiness'. But little else is known about this being and the ancient, hidden world in which he existed, except that it was a world in which everything was possible—the gardens grew by themselves, there was never any shortage of food, and so on.

For all Baniwa, the first world came to an end when the great world tree called *Kaali-ka thidzapa*[9]—which connected the Other World of the deities with This World—was cut down. The felling of the tree initiated the second period of the universe which is the epoch when the creator deity *Nhiãperikuli* walked on the earth and obtained things in this world: the earth itself, the gardens, day and night, cooking fire, fish; in short, all things with which humanity could live in this world and prosper. Baniwa cosmogony is remembered in a complex set of over twenty myths, the main protagonist of which is the creator/transformer *Nhiãperikuli*, beginning with his emergence in the primordial world and ending with his creation of the first ancestors of the Baniwa phratries and withdrawal from the world. Many of these myths recount the struggles of *Nhiãperikuli* against various animal- and fish-peoples who seek to kill him and destroy the order of the universe. More than any other figure of the Baniwa pantheon, *Nhiãperikuli* was responsible for the form and essence of the world; in fact, it may even be said that he *is* the ontological principle that governs the universe.[10] As narrators state, *Nhiãperikuli*

9. This was the tree from which *pariká*, shamans' snuff, was obtained. If it was an Anadenanthera tree, these grow to as high as sixty feet tall; the Virola trees grow to as high as one-hundred forty feet, with bases of up to five meters in diameter. The name refers to a hill (in Baniwa, *hidzapa*) on the upper Uaupés River where there is a huge stone which is the petrified stump of the Great Tree of *Kaali*.

10. The notion of 'governing the world' is implicit in the phrases which the Baniwa use to express their relation to their creator and other divinities: as 'owners' or 'patrons' (*iminali*) and as 'masters' (*thayri*) or 'priests'. *Nhiãperikuli*, *Kuwai*, and *Dzuliferi* are all considered the 'owners of the world' (*hekwapi iminali*). This 'proprietary' relation means that, through their actions, they caused things, conditions, and places to come into being, leaving them after their deaths for posterity, as an inheritance. *Nhiãperikuli* made 'everything in the world' and gave it to the Baniwa with instructions on how to live well on it. *Dzuliferi* is the 'owner' of shamans' snuff, *pariká*, and

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'foresaw' how things should be in this world for all future generations (*walimanai*, 'for all those who will be born').

Another great cycle in the history of the cosmos is told in the myth of *Kuwai*, the son of *Nhiãperikuli* and the first woman, *Amaru*. This myth has central importance in Baniwa culture for it explains major questions on the nature of existence in this world: how the order and ways of life of the ancestors were/are reproduced for all future generations, the *Walimanai*; how children are to be instructed in initiation rituals about the nature of the world; how sicknesses and misfortune entered the world; and what is the nature of the relation among humans, spirits, and animals that is the legacy of the primordial world. The myth tells of the life of *Kuwai* who is an extraordinary being, whose body is full of holes and consists of all the elements, all the animals of the world, and whose humming and songs produce all animal species. Like *Kaali-ka thidzapa*, *Kuwai* was an undifferentiated all-beings-in-one. His birth set in motion a rapid process of growth in which the miniature and chaotic world of *Nhiãperikuli* opened up to its real-life size.

tobacco; he gave them to *Nhiãperikuli* who left them to posterity, especially for the shamans 'to know the world'. *Kuwai* is the 'owner of sickness' and the 'owner of poison' who left them in all their forms in this world, but he also taught the shamans how to cure them. In the broadest sense, *Nhiãperikuli*, his brothers, and *Kuwai* are considered to be 'our owners' (*waminali*), for humanity lives, prospers, and grows in the order and the conditions inherited from them. The relation of divinities/humanity is brought into experience through, for example, shamans, who request from the 'owners' remedies with which to cure, which may involve bargaining, for the patient must present a material offering or payment (*dawai*), which the shaman then takes to *Kuwai* in order to bargain for the return of his soul. This payment may be refused if it is judged to be insufficient, or the sickness deemed incurable. The relation of 'master' or 'priest' (*-thayri)* in the Other World is applied to the same triad, *Nhiãperikuli*, *Kuwai*, *Dzuliferi*, all of whom are considered the 'Masters/Chiefs/Priests of the World' (*Hekwapi-thayri*), 'eternal masters/priests', 'masters from the beginning'. Another deity, *Kaali*, is also called 'Master/Priest' because he gave to humanity all cultivated plants for their gardens and the planting ceremonies. In many respects, *Kaali* is like *Nhiãperikuli*, and some narrators are even more explicit: '*Kaali* is really *Nhiãperikuli*' one shaman said. In the myth about his life and death, *Kaali* sacrifices himself in a huge earth-fire and from the white earth that was left at the place where he was burned (the word *kaali* also means 'white earth'), the first manioc tree emerged, from which humanity obtained all the plants they needed. In other words, he gave of himself for the needs of others. His body is manioc bread, or *beiju*. Catholic missionaries have equated *Kaali* with Adam, the first man made of the earth. However simplistic this may be, *Kaali* is the deity who taught humanity how to plant their gardens, and how to sing and pray at the time of planting. This suggests that a more adequate translation for the term '*thayri*' may in fact be 'priests' because it is canonical knowledge that he transmits to his children.

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This period ended with the felling of another great world tree, or axis mundi, which likewise connected This World with the Other World and which was produced from the body of *Kuwai*, who was sacrificed in a great fire at the end of the first rite of initiation. At the place where *Kuwai* was burned, an enormous paxiuba palm tree burst out from the earth up to the sky. When this great tree was felled, *Nhiãperikuli* produced from its pieces the first sacred flutes and trumpets, which are the 'body of *Kuwai*', with which the men initiate their children today. The idea is that the sacred flutes represent the principle of social and cultural reproduction—the means by which culture is transmitted over time—and in fact everything which *Nhiãperikuli* had obtained, which was left for all future generations. Like the felling of the *Kaali-ka thidzapa* from which all of humanity got their food, the felling of the *Kuwai* tree left humanity with the instruments with which humans could reproduce their society. After this, *Nhiãperikuli* purified the world, washing it and ridding it of all predatory beings and malignant spirits, and then brought forth humanity.

The myth of *Kuwai* thus marks a transition between the primordial world of *Nhiãperikuli* and a more recent human past, which is brought directly into the experience of living people in the rituals. For that reason, the shamans say that *Kuwai* is as much a part of the present world as of the ancient world, and that he lives 'in the center of the world'. The shamans seek *Kuwai* in their cures, for his body consists of all sicknesses that exist in the world—including poison used in witchcraft, which still is the most frequently cited 'cause' of death of people today. The material forms of witchcraft *Kuwai* left as poisonous plants in this world in the great conflagration that marked his 'death' and withdrawal from the world. At the precise moment of his burning, he left his liver, *lixupana*, which became the poisonous plant called *hueero*. Following that, a class of spirits called *Yoopinai* emerged from the ashes of *Kuwai*'s body. These spirits take the material forms of sickness-giving plants, insects, lizards, spiders, and so on. The poisonous fur from *Kuwai*'s body then 'entered' the body fur of the black sloth *wamu*, which is the deity *Kuwai*'s animal-body form in this world. This sloth has fur containing an enormous variety of fungae that may give sickness to humans, and whose sudden appearance is considered an omen (*lhinimai*) of peoples' deaths. Many, but not all, of the Yoopinai took on the material form of plants; they are thought of as a tribe of spirit-'people' whose 'chief' has the body of a lizard (*dopo)* and, 'as a person', he is described as a powerful, white, dwarf-shaman with long, loose hair, a golden chain around his neck, a large cigar, and is a mortal enemy of humans.

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Once the sacred instruments had been fabricated, the creator deities went to *Hipana* falls on the Aiary River, the sacred place where *Kuwai* was born and died, the center of the world connection between the Upper and Lower worlds, and brought forth the first *Kuwai*-ancestors of the phratries.[11] These were not entirely human yet; they were a mixture of flute and body form. The fully human ancestors, with bodies like humanity has today, were born later. When these phratric ancestors were born, the creator deities—*Nhiãperikuli*, *Dzuliferi*, *Eeri* —stood over the holes in the center of the rapids[12] and watched as each came out. Each ancestor was given sacred pepper and tobacco, sacred names of the ancestors, and sent to the places where they were to live and plant their gardens.

Humanity today lives in the third period of cosmic history. Evangelicals believe that this third period will likewise come to an end. But to non-evangelicals, only shamans are capable of 'seeing' and knowing when the end of the world will occur. At the time when the first evangelical missionaries arrived among the Baniwa in the late 1940s, it is said that some of the shamans foresaw that great transformations were about to occur and that the world would return to its initial paradisiacal and miraculous state. Indeed, this prophecy resonated with the first missionary's announcement that the end of time and the imminent coming of Christ was at hand.

In Baniwa cosmology, the universe is formed by multiple layers, associated with various divinities, spirits, and 'other people'. According to one very knowledgeable shaman, it is organized into an enormous vertical structure of twenty-five layers or 'worlds' (*kuma*), there being twelve layers below This World (*hliekwapi*) of humans—collectively known as *Uapinakuethe*, 'Place of Our Bones'—and twelve above, collectively known as *Apakwa Hekwapi*, the 'Other World'. Each one of the layers below the earth is inhabited by 'people' or 'tribes' with distinctive characteristics (people painted red, people with large mouths, etc.). With the exception of the people of the lowest level of the cosmos, and one other place of the underworld, all other peoples are considered to be 'good' and assist the shamans in their search for the lost souls of the sick. Above our world are the places of various spirits and divinities related to the shamans: bird-spirits who help the shamans in their search for lost souls; the Owner of Sicknesses, *Kuwai*, whom the shaman seeks to cure

11. Phratries are groups of clans or sibs that consider themselves to be 'brothers'; they are ranked in relation to each other according to their birth order—elder brother, younger brother.

12. People who have seen these say that they form almost perfectly round and very deep holes in the center of the rapids, which can be seen in the dry season.

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more serious ailments; the primordial shamans and *Dzulíferi*, the Owner of *pariká* (shaman's snuff) and tobacco; and finally, the place of the Creator and Transformer *Nhiãperikuli*, or 'Dio' which is a place of eternal, brilliant light, like a room full of mirrors reflecting this light. While *Nhiãperikuli* is light, the sun is a manifestation of his body. With the exception of the level of *Kuwai*, all other levels are likewise inhabited by 'good people'. Some may 'delude' or 'lie' to the shaman, but only the 'sickness owner' possesses death-dealing substances used in witchcraft.

The 'Fruit' of Creation: Pariká

Pariká (*Virola calophylla*, *Anadenanthera* spp.) is a psychoactive snuff widely used by the shamans of the Northwest Amazon, especially, but not exclusively, for rituals of curing. It is sometimes used together with another psychoactive, *caapi* (*Banisteriopsis* sp.), although the mixture of the two was more common in the past when, oral histories relate, prophets could enhance their visionary powers in their struggles to eliminate witchcraft and sorcery. Such visions were fundamental to the restoration of the internal social order constantly threatened by both negative internal forces and exploitation, often with violence, by the White Man. Through their psychoactive powers to reveal, to open communication with the 'Other World' and the deceased who advised and counseled their living kin on events that were about to happen, the two substances had a fundamental role in restoring harmonious conviviality at various critical moments in history.[13] Various myths explain how

13. *Pariká* has been used by indigenous peoples of several language groupings distributed over a vast area of western South America. Undoubtedly the most complete and original study of *pariká* is the doctoral thesis by Wolfgang Kapfhammer (1997), *The Great Serpent and the Flying Jaguar*, which seeks to develop a dynamic panorama rooted in shamanism and cosmology. Inspired by Johannes Wilbert's classic study, *Tobacco and Shamanism* (1987), and in the comparative methods of Lawrence Sullivan and Otto Zerries, Kapfhammer focuses a good part of his analysis on the iconography and ritual instruments found in South America. He argues against the existence of a complex of predetermined perceptions and sensations that the effect of the snuff has in relation to mythological and cosmological themes specific to each culture; rather, he argues that the snuff serves as a 'trigger' for certain sensations and perceptions, which, up to a certain point, are structured by pharmacologically induced processes, but these in no way determine cultural understanding of these perceptions.

The author also analyzes the complex iconology present in a rich variety of paraphernalia used in rites of *pariká*. His analysis of motifs reveals a connection between the rites and seasonal cycles. Thus, serpentine forms found on the *pariká* trays used by the Sateré-Mawé are associated with the rainy season, the constellations of the Great Serpent, the predominance of sickness during this time, and the presence of female

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shamans obtained *pariká*, but the most important one consists of a set of episodes in which *Nhiãperikuli* and his brothers find the powers and instruments of the shamans (collectively known as *malikhai*)—powers to see and to transform, to become invisible, to sound thunder, a jaguar-tooth collar (the main adornment of the jaguar-shaman), and *pariká*. In the first episode, *Nhiãperikuli's* younger brother desires to learn how to make the sound of thunder; he seeks and finds the harpy eagle, *Kamathawa*. The eagle gives him one of his crest feathers and tells him to sniff it; suddenly, as if smitten by a charge of energy, the young man's vision 'opens' and he begins to 'see' as the shamans see today. He sees the eagle then as a person. Next, the eagle gives him another feather from his body and tells him to sniff it, and, smitten again, the young apprentice makes the sound of thunder. With these powers, he returns home and meets his brother *Nhiãperikuli*, but the young apprentice is invisible, for he had acquired the power to transform and to leave his visible body.[14] Thus, the first episode relates how the primal shamans acquired some of their most fundamental powers—to see, to sound thunder, and to transform. All of this occurred in the Other World, the World before the present one of humans. They still had not found *pariká*, the means by which the shamans today acquire the same powers.

The second episode revolves around the felling of *Kaali-ka thidzapa*, that connected the two levels of the universe still in formation at that time, and which was the source of all the cultivated plants in the world. *Pariká* is a 'little fruit' (or bean) found inside a hole at the top of the huge tree. Once the tree was felled—the best narrators skillfully heighten the expectancy of the event—*Nhiãperikuli* could not get the *pariká* because of swarms of bees that prevented him from getting near the hole. Suddenly the tapir plows his way through the brush and, with his thick hide, is able to get the *pariká* without getting stung by the bees. The tapir is characterized in this story as a gluttonous and selfish animal, and he takes all of the shaman's powers for himself, the jaguar-tooth collar and the *pariká*, stealing them from their rightful owner, *Nhiãperikuli*.

primordial beings who keep the snuff inside their vaginas. Other myths associate predatory birds, such as the harpy, the dry season, and icons on the paraphernalia, thus complementing the symbolic values related to the Great Serpent. In short, Kapfhammer provides a rich analysis connecting ritual use of snuff and meteorological cycles; and it is well known that one of the shamans' most important functions is control over seasonal transitions.

14. In Baniwa belief, the body is 'like a shirt' (*kamitsa*, from the Portuguese word for shirt) a covering for the 'person' *(newiki)*. In myths, primordial beings are constantly leaving or exchanging bodies; one being may have several bodies but remains the 'same' being.

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Figure 2. *Anadenanthera* spp.

In possession of the *pariká*, the tapir calls his companions together to sniff the psychoactive powder. The tapir immediately becomes a ferocious jaguar who growls that he wants 'to eat people without stopping'. The catastrophe that this could have caused led *Nhiãperikuli* to simply snatch the *pariká* away from the tapir, giving him a sound tap on his snout, and giving him a miriti fruit (blood-red in color) to eat. Even then, the myth continues, *Nhiãperikuli* takes the miriti fruit away, leaving the tapir totally inoffensive, eating leaves, which is what he does today. The tapir's companions, one after another, 'go crazy' (*napikaka)* on *pariká:* one falls down in a drunken trance, another falls into the river and emerges as an otter, and the last runs into the forest and transforms into a forest-spirit. The acquisition of shamanic powers and the use of *pariká* by non-apprentices provoke alterations in the perceptions of the subjects: the tapir, an already gluttonous and selfish animal, becomes an insatiable jaguar, but is quickly reduced to an inoffensive leaf-eater.[15]

In the final episode, the spatial and temporal separation between the primordial shamans and the human level of the cosmos occurs through

15. The shaman can also 'transform into', or, more precisely, acquire the perspective of a variety of other predatory animals—the alligator, anaconda, eagle.

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the ascension of the *wakaawenai*, primordial shamans, to the heavens and their definitive withdrawal from the human world. These shamans simply took *pariká* and 'went away', transforming with their song, rising body and soul to the sky. They live eternally in the Other World where they are seen only by the shamans of today who visit these realms. In the story, however, their ascension (*hirali*) seems to represent the idea that the primordial shamans 'never died'. Their transformation through their song was a passage from one world to the other, whole, without the normal separation between body and souls that takes place at death. At the end of the myth, only *Nhiãperikuli* stayed in this world of the future humans, preparing everything for the existence to come. *Pariká*, the means by which shamans travel to the Other World, was given, as was the whole practice of the shamans: 'they are doctors', one of the narrators said, for 'they extract sickness, they revive people well. They help us well. That is the truth'.

It should be clear that what the story relates is the creation of the Other World (*Apakwa Hekwapi)*, distinct from This World of humans, separated by the felling of the Great Tree. The cutting of the tree provoked a rupture in the 'univocality' (Sullivan 1988) of the primordial world, but it also was followed by, first, a brief struggle for shamanic power, *malikhai*, between the animals and *Nhiãperikuli*'s tribe of shamans, the *wakaawenai.* The animals acquire powers that they cannot have, exacerbating their animal attributes. Tapir is a glutton and becomes an insatiable jaguar, a powerfully shamanic being. *It is the mixing of what cannot by their very nature be mixed that produces the catastrophe.* The tapir and his companions 'go mad', that is, are unable to control the transformation that *pariká* produces. Thus, the proper ownership falls to *Nhiãperikuli* and the true shamans. A second major consequence of the felling of the tree is the 'distribution' (*liniuetaka)* of cultivated plants to all the tribes who came and took their share of food (manioc sprigs, potatoes, etc.) back to their villages. It was from that time that plants multiplied and covered the earth as the Baniwa knew it. All of these were gifts from *Nhiãperikuli* to humanity, showing his generosity and mindfulness of future generations, their descendants.

The episode of the felling of the tree can also be interpreted to refer to the beginning of various interconnected food chains: the annual agricultural cycle synchronized with meteorological phenomena, fishing activities associated with the levels of the rivers, and the appearance of species of sauva ants. As J. Hill explains: 'When the level of the rivers begins to go down and fishing begins to improve after a long rainy season…the men select and cut the new gardens according to the mythical calendar of Kaali' (1984: 532), and, 'the general belief underlying all the phases of

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the annual cycle of agriculture is that people can facilitate agricultural labor by synchronizing their activities with the mythical calendar of…Kaali and his children' (1984: 533). Thus, in the myth, while the primordial shamans are cutting the great tree down, the tapir fishes in the large fishtraps. Again, Hill clarifies:

> The annual cycle reaches its high point with the main planting of the new gardens of manioc at the end of the long dry season. This period, called *walipere inuma* (the 'mouth') or beginning of the Pleiades also is the time of spectacular spawning-runs of various species of fish. These species return every year to the same streams and appear in recently flooded areas of the forest and open fields. The mouths of the streams are then blocked off with large fish traps after a school of fish swim by to the lake upriver (1984: 535).

This period also corresponds to the annual cycle of exchange festivals, or *pudali*, when groups of kin and affines drink and dance together. For the Baniwa, the fish during their annual fish-runs are doing precisely the same thing as humans do in their celebration of exchange and dance festivals.

Another story of *pariká* tells that the brownish-red snuff was actually the menstrual blood of *Dzuliferi*'s daughter, and *Nhiãperikuli* took it from her vagina while she slept. *Dzuliferi* reprehended his brother for this act, as did all of the primal shamans who collectively went away to live in the sky-world. It was *Nhiãperikuli's* improper relation to a menstruating woman that produced the separation between him and his brother-shamans. But, the association of *pariká* with menstrual blood has a counterpart in the way shamans refer to it today as 'the blood, the first menstrual blood of *Kuwai*' (*Kuwai irana, likanupa Kuwai*),[11] which certainly suggests that *Kuwai* is a liminal being, both male and female, who is not 'of this world', and who is both a sickness-giving spirit and a great healer. *In short, this deity is the paradoxical unity of opposites, extremely dangerous should it mix with the uninitiated and women*. To develop this further would require a great deal more ethnographic background, which space does not permit here.

11. The key notion of *-kanupa* can be translated as the dangerous state of being 'mixed'. Its indissociable complement is that of tabu, separate, 'closed'(*itakawa*). All of *Kuwai*'s body is full of holes, *kanupa*. At girls' first menstruation, they are also said to be *kanupa*, and it is interesting that the Arawak-speaking Tariana people, who were once neighbors to the Baniwa of the Aiary, used masks to represent *Kue (= Kuwai)* who appeared as masked dancers at the initiation rituals. The masks were made out of woven hair that had been cut at girls' first menstruation ceremonies, along with the fur of the black sloth. The masked figure would appear with a whip in hand and—one detail that was noted about his body—it had three claws on its paw, just like the sloth.

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A third story tells how shamanic knowledge was 'distributed' to all the Baniwa villages. Initially, a child of the sun (not *Kuwai)* snuffed *pariká* and transformed into a very powerful black jaguar whose predatory powers came to be so dangerous that his father had to sacrifice him, later throwing his dead body into the river. At every village the body passed, the inhabitants would take a piece of the body—even the brains, which went to a people who later became very powerful jaguar-shamans. Thus jaguar shamanism was distributed to all Baniwa villages, and, until their conversion to evangelicalism, most Baniwa villages had several of these practicing jaguar shamans.

Shamanic Experiences with the 'Teacher' Plant

As we have seen in the first myth, *pariká* has the marked effect of 'opening the [shaman's] vision', stimulating clairvoyance. In cosmology, *pariká* is intimately connected to shamanic voyages to all other levels of the cosmos, even to the place of *Nhiãperikuli*. The shamans sing that *pariká* 'raises a stairway' for the shaman to ascend to the other levels of the cosmos. With *pariká* the shaman transforms into (that is, he acquires the agentivity of) a series of other spirit-beings, for his soul has left his body and thus can assume any number of forms.



Figure 3. Shamans' souls voyage on *pariká*

The shamans' descriptions of their experiences with *pariká* can be very elaborate. Here, I cite selected parts of the discourse by one of the most

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experienced shamans, Mandu, with whom I have worked since my first field trip in the 1970s. Thirty years later, we still maintain contact by telephone conversations, and, with the generous help of his daughter, he continues to teach me many aspects of his art and practice through taped and filmed interviews.

In this interview, taped in the 1970s, he spoke of his travels to the Other World, encounters with the divinities, and the powers that *pariká* gives to the shamans. He began his apprenticeship as the result of a sickness, attributed to witchcraft, which nearly killed him. He had a vision in his sleep of a powerful shaman who came to cure him and told him to return home from his journey to the houses of the dead. After Mandu recovered, his parents sent him to learn from the same master shaman who had cured him in his dream. I asked him to speak about *pariká* and the following are some passages of what he said:

> Long ago *Nhiãperikuli* made these shamans' things for us. Then he gave us these healing things. For us, our people. So we snuff this *pariká*, that lets us know the world. For, since the beginning of time this *pariká* has been in existence, for a long time we have had *pariká.* From the beginning of time we have this *pariká*, this way to know the world. He gave us his blood, the blood of *Kuwai*, which is *pariká*. The owner of *pariká* is *Dzulíferi*. *Dzulíferi* is the owner of *pariká* and of all the sickness-things. But he gave them to us, to us the people, our *pariká*. Thus, they snuff *pariká*, and then they see with *pariká.* They see this *Dzulíferi*, they see this *Kuwai*. Then they see this, our owner also, *Nhiãperikuli*. Then they see this *Kamathawa* [harpy eagle, pet of *Nhiãperikuli*] also. *Dzulíferi* also gave us tobacco, this *Dzulíferi* is the owner of tobacco, the owner of tobacco. But this tobacco is his plant, this *Dzulíferi.*
> …
>
> …Thus, it seems, what the master of the world said, thus the *pajés*[16] return and tell it to the people. The *pajés* cannot speak nonsense, about what the master of the world said. The *pajé* tells the people well, just as the owner of knowledge told him. The owner of knowledge said this and that, in such a way that the *pajés* are capable of understanding how it is. About this world also. They are capable of knowing everything about the world, about sickness too. Thus, the *pajé* tells what *Dzulíferi* said, this owner of *pariká*, what he said, it seems, to his kin.
>
> Later the *pajé* tells his kin other things also, everything that our owner *Nhiãperikuli* told him, about what is going to happen in this world. The *pajé* tells them what our owner said. Then, the *pajé* comes back and tells his kin, what they saw and what the owner of the world showed to them…
>
> *Pariká* changes everything, it shows everything to the *pajés* whatever it may be. With it, this *pariká*, the *pajés* are capable of knowing the world. *Pariká* shows to you in order that you see not just anything, it seems…

16. *Pajés* are shamans (in Baniwa, *maliiri*). *Pajé* is more commonly used in Amazonia, so it will be left as such in the text.

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> (…) After they know everything about the world, the pajé comes back and tells the people. They tell everything to the people how it is in the beginning, before them, as *Nhiãperikuli* told the *pajés*. The *pajés* can become like the master of the world, in their thought also. They make the world. They can, in their thought (…). Everything—they cannot deceive on that. They become very much like—like *Nhiãperikuli* was, so they are. There, the *pajés* are like *Nhiãperikuli*. They make everything. They make the rocks, they make the wood, they transform everything with *pariká*. They transform themselves into wood, they transform themselves into jaguars, they transform themselves into alligators, they transform themselves into dolphins, they transform themselves into vultures, all of that in their thought—they transform themselves into people also. Thus also, it seems, they transform themselves into the master of the world. Then they are capable of knowing the world.

Several points are important to note in this discourse: first, *pariká* is what can be called a 'teacher plant', for it shows the shaman everything he needs to know about the universe and things that are happening in it or are about to happen. It is this knowledge that the shaman/*pajé* is expected to teach his people. Mandu stressed that the *pajé* has the obligation to tell the people exactly what the deities told him; as an emissary from the divinities, his messages are of vital importance not only for the well-being of the patients whom he is treating, but also for the community and its collective future. Secondly, and most importantly, *pariká* propitiates the altered state of consciousness that allows the *pajé* to know and to do what other sacred beings and divinities know and do. That is to say, *pariká* propitiates the alteration of perspectives, in which the shaman acquires the perspectives and agentivity of other kinds of beings (see M. Carneiro da Cunha [1999], for a similar conclusion among *pajés* of the southern Amazon). In 'becoming like *Nhiãperikuli*' and transforming everything that exists in this world,[18] Mandu explained that:

> The *pajé* seeks the hidden world, the first world of *Nhiãperikuli*. In his thought the *pajé* stays where *Nhiãperikuli* is and seeks to open [that is, reveal] this hidden world. He uses the log and the feathers of the harpy eagle *Kamathawa* in order to open it. This hidden world is the place of happiness. When the hidden world opens for the *pajé*, he goes up to it. He sits in the place of *Dzuliferi* and opens the world again. The *pajé* is near *Nhiãperikuli* and sees the entire world. He can make everything as *Nhiãperikuli* made in the beginning: as *Nhiãperikuli* saw the world in the beginning in his thought.[17] Then he can make the world. The *pajé* stays near the

18. For a more complete discussion of these discourses, see Wright 1998, 2005.

17. *That is, as he formed an image of it*. One article which I find helpful in understanding the discourses of the shaman about this 'hidden world' is by Overing, 'Shaman as a Maker of Worlds' (1990).

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> eternal sun in order to open the ancient and hidden world of *Nhiãperikuli*. He sees the world becoming happy, that all people become happy, as in the beginning. Thus the *pajé* makes the world better, not letting it come to an end. The *pajé* knows when the world is going to come to an end; he advises *Nhiãperikuli* and he doesn't allow it to come to an end.

Here we have an extraordinary statement by a *pajé* of the salvific power he detains. It is *pariká* that shows (*inhata)* the *pajé* all of this through a series of visions of the Other World. What is the 'ancient, hidden world of happiness' that the *pajé* reveals? Is it perhaps the first world, that existed before the felling of the Great Tree of *Kaali*, when everything would get done by itself, when people did not have to suffer or die, when there was no poison or witchcraft in the world? Access to this hidden world is restricted only to the most powerful of the *pajés*, very few indeed have attained it—only the true prophets of whom there have been several since the mid-nineteenth century (see Wright 1981, 2002, 2005). Through the psychoactive effects of *pariká*, the *pajé* 'raises the stairs' (an image common to shamanism throughout the world) to the Other World; he sees and communicates with the primordial beings who inhabit the sky. These inform, advise, and assist him not only on the form, character, and treatment of the sick in This World, but also of all that is about to happen. This is undoubtedly what makes *pariká* the most sacred of plants that the Baniwa shamans know.[18]

The Primordial Plantations

The following story is one narrator's version of how the earth for gardens came into being and how one important 'soul-food', tobacco, was obtained by *Nhiãperikuli*; both are among the gifts the deities left for humanity.

Nhiãperikuli Looks for the Earth, Gardens and Tobacco
(told by Luis Manuel of Ukuki village)

> When *Kuwai* was born, for him our orphan father *Nhiãperikuli*,[19] at his birth, *Kuwai* was very small, very small was his child. Then *Kuwai* shat,

18. Shamans used to use *Banisteriopsis caapi*, *yaje* (*ayahuasca*), sometimes together with *pariká* (see Wright 2005), but this practice seems to have become extremely restricted to one or two *pajés* today.

19. *Nhiãperikuli* is called the 'orphan' because, as some narrators say, his father and mother had been devoured by the animal-tribes that wandered over the first world, killing and eating people. Other narrators say that in the beginning, there was just a bone inside the 'pot of the sun'. That bone was *Nhiãperikuli*, for the name literally means 'He-inside-the-bone'.

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shat, and shat… This earth is his shit, the shit of *Kuwai* is this earth. The earth grew a little, it was so small the earth was, thus was the earth long ago, the first world for us. His earth then, of our orphan father was a stone, thus, it was a stone, his village was of stone.

So *Nhiãperikuli* thought about this earth—was there no way for him to get earth for the people to plant, to get plants for people to put in their gardens? So he got earth from *Kuwai*. Like so, the first earth was very little. The earth grew… *Kuwai* shat the earth, …*Nhiãperikuli* saw it. Then, the one that the Whites call Adam, but that we know as *Kaali* in Baniwa, he saw the earth and got it with *Nhiãperikuli* to make gardens on it. After that, *Kaali* made gardens on it. After he made the gardens, then he got the food for us that truly we have today as it was in the beginning. *Kaali* got plants from *Kuwai*…all of them! Yams, bananas, all the plants… They were his, *Kuwai*'s. *Kaali*, the one they call Adam, looked and got plants for their plantations. Things for gardens, thus they made. Thus, in the beginning, the earth was, since the beginning, for gardens. Then after, it was from then on truly that we grew on it until today. That's all, but the earth was very small in the beginning. (…)

After that, *Nhiãperikuli* looked for this tobacco, *Nhiãperikuli* got it from *Dzuuli* [*Dzuliferi*, his brother]. He got it from *Dzuuli* first! In the beginning. This tobacco, *Nhiãperikuli* knows that it is good, 'Give me a little, my brother', he said to *Dzuuli*. 'So it is, I give it to you', *Dzuuli* said to *Nhiãperikuli*. He gave it to him, but it was his dry tobacco. 'No, I want the other kind that's green for me to plant, a basketful of it', *Nhiãperikuli said*. 'Go back home then', *Dzuuli* said, 'I will deliver it'. So *Dzuuli* would deliver it to *Nhiãperikuli's* village. *Dzuuli* went and there he met *Nhiãperikuli*'s children there. *Dzuuli* approached them… He met those children, he came up to them. He delivered the tobacco to them. 'Where is *Nhiãperikuli*?' he asked the children. 'He went out', they answered. 'I have brought tobacco, this good tobacco for him', *Dzuuli* said to those children. 'This good tobacco for him, I will leave the tobacco for him there behind the house', *Dzuuli* said. He went to the back of the house and planted the tobacco. 'Now I am going away from you', he said and that's all, he left them and went back home.

It was night when *Nhiãperikuli* returned and asked the children, 'where is *Dzuuli*?' 'He's already gone back,' they answered, 'but he left something good for you'. The night passed… The tobacco then grew and grew. *Nhiãperikuli* went to the back of his house and went out to see… *Nhiãperikuli* went out and saw that it was full of tobacco. 'Ooooh, so it will be', he said, 'For our descendants, for our others who will be born'. Then, he divided it up for everyone, today, all our tobacco. All the tobacco that the Whites have… There, those Whites what they have is different from ours… What the Whites have, we don't know how it is. This, what I am telling you, is *ours, of our people*!

The episodes of the story begin with similar primordial conditions which are static or sterile (the first earth is a rock, the excrement of *Kuwai*; *Nhiãperikuli* has the dry tobacco and wants the green kind in order to

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plant); a different condition is sought (*Kaali* gets the earth and plants from *Kuwai*; *Nhiãperikuli* gets the green kind of tobacco from *Dzuliferi*) which is described as 'good'. This different condition is introduced and, in the process, a transformation occurs in which a new, dynamic order is created: the earth is cultivated with plants; the strong, green tobacco is domesticated.[20] The new order of fertility sustains life for humanity, and is *given to* humanity, defining a meaningful and symbolic order in which people can live and be prosperous.

The story of *Kaali*, however, continues beyond his obtaining the earth and plants for plantations and develops over a series of episodes. Several narrators thought that the figure of *Kaali* was really *Nhiãperikuli*; others that they were distinct. All agreed that he was the source of *cultivated* plants, especially manioc.[21] Yet the story above states that he obtained all plants from *Kuwai*. This is not necessarily a contradiction, for *Kaali* was responsible for cultivated garden plants, while *Kuwai* is associated with all fruits and palm trees.

The time sequence of all these stories, of who came first, seems to matter little to narrators, really, since they all lived in the same 'old times' (*oopidali*). While the story of the Great Tree of *Kaali* ends with cultivated plants being distributed to 'all the tribes' (with, of course, the narrator's people getting more), the following story of *Kaali* and his family has to do with the relations of garden production. The important episode in *Kaali*'s life occurred after he was married and had several children. According to one narrator, he attempted to plant manioc in his son's wife's body, making—so it would seem—a garden in her belly, as though she would then give birth to the plant. She quarreled with him over this, *Kaali*'s wife quarreled with him, and the girl's father quarreled with him. Consequently, he took all of the plants from his garden and

20. Another episode not included in this narrative tells how *Nhiãperikuli* obtained night. In the beginning it was always day; *Nhiãperikuli's* wife tells him to get night from her father. The 'owner of night' gives *Nhiãperikuli* a small and tightly shut little basket, with instructions to open it only when he got back to his village. The basket was so heavy that *Nhiãperikuli* stopped midway back home and opened the basket. Darkness burst out covering the world. *Nhiãperikuli* and the animals and birds ascended the trees and waited until they saw the sun returning from its journey across the underworld and back. *Nhiãperikuli* had made the sun come back. Henceforth, time was divided into two equal cycles: day, when people would work in their gardens, and night, when people would rest.

21. One narrator said he also made several species of deer from a manioc plant, which is why the deer like to eat manioc leaves. Other stories seem to link *Nhiãperikuli* and *Kaali* through animals that like to eat manioc leaves and manioc bread.

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abandoned his family, going to live far away.[22] His children and wife were left without food, and they were unable to plant new gardens since *Kaali* made it rain every day. One day, while *Kaali*'s sons were trying to set fire to the garden before planting, their father appeared to them announcing that he would leave them forever. He started the fire in the garden, then he got his ceremonial dance-staff, his shield, and his drum. He ordered his son to give him a bit of manioc beer to drink and, when the fire was burning high, he told him to push him into it. 'Why do you want me to do this to you, father?' the son said, 'Why do I have to burn you, father?' And his son pushed him into the fire. As he burned, *Kaali* said, 'Come back one week from now to see your garden! For, she, your mother, will never know how the garden was planted'. At the appointed time, his wife and children went back and saw that the garden was full of every kind of manioc, pineapples, bananas, and other fruits. *Kaali* had left them with an abundance of food. A huge manioc tree stood in the garden and one of his sons cut it down. *Kaali*'s wife began the process of scraping manioc tubers. His son prayed with tobacco at the center of the garden.[23] *Kaali*'s body lay in the earth; his knowledge (that is, all horticultural knowledge) spread (was distributed, *liniuetaka*) all over the earth. 'Only one thing he left for us to eat: manioc bread, *pete*, this is his body. "My body it will be", he said. "You will eat it in this world"' (ACIRA 1999: 112-15).

A simple reading of the story would say that the father/hero's 'deed' of trying to make his daughter-in-law a manioc woman failed, and a grave intra-familial conflict situation arose. To resolve the conflict, the father abandons his family, taking all of his plants to two hills where he lived alone. Seeing his family in desperate hunger, the father decides to

22. At the hills called *Waliro* at the headwaters of the Cuiary River. Some narrators say that the reason why *Kaali* abandoned them was that his sons refused to work in the gardens.

23. Today, at the planting of new gardens, a lengthy prayer to *Kaali thayri*, *Kaali* priest (or master) is spoken to make the earth fertile for planting. It is called 'turning the earth' and various parts of fishes are mixed in with the earth to 'make the earth good'. Each of the species of fish and animals invoked in this prayer has the name of a body part of *Kaali*. Then, an image of the body of *Kaali* is made, complete with his lance, painted, and then 'lifted up' by the back, 'in order to make what we plant grow well'. Great lizards are called from the four directions to bring various plants from the Sun to the center of the garden. Again, these plants all have the names of parts of K*aali*'s body, as well as body parts of various other deities. Finally, the planter takes earth in his hands and says: 'I will see like the child of the Sun, I will plant'. (Note how 'seeing' and making things come into being are again associated.) With all of this correctly done, the garden will grow well.

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sacrifice himself, leaving his body in the earth, which produced the cultivated plants that were no longer his but of his entire family, indeed all the peoples of the earth. Perhaps the most intriguing part of the story, though, is how *Kaali* puts on the vestments of a ceremonial priest (shield, staff, and the title *-thayri*, which could be rendered as 'master'—in the sense of a spiritual master, i.e. 'priest') suggesting that *Kaali* is the earthly equivalent of the creator of humanity, *Nhiãperikuli*, and that, in the past, there was a more elaborate ritual than what exists today. Some of the prophets in Baniwa history were known by the rituals they performed in the gardens, to make the gardens grow well (Wright 1981, 2005).

Catholic priests have insisted with the Baniwa that *Kaali*, being of the earth, is in reality Adam of the Christian religion. 'The first man made of earth', associated with a primordial tree that contains shamanic knowledge, is suggestive of the biblical image of Eden. This interpretation, however, fails to see that *Kaali* is the god of all cultivated food and is himself food, having sacrificed himself of his own will in order to resolve a situation of conflict in relations of production. In his comparative works, the German ethnologist Alfred Jensen gathered numerous examples of myths from Asiatic, African, Oceanic and South American 'horticultural' (*Pflänzerkulturen*) societies (Jensen 1948). The dramatic climax of these narrations was the killing of a primordial being, whose dismembered body parts transformed themselves into cultivated plants. Central to this religious belief, held by Jensen to be a creation of the first horticulturalists, is the cultivated plant. In accordance with its importance for humans, it is taken to be divine, but nevertheless or *because* of this, the divine being has to be killed, for growth would only be conceivable in close association with death. For Jensen, the 'Killed Deity' (Jensen 1948) embodies one and the same idea: killing is a prerequisite for growth, and the primordial killing, which brought food and life to humans, has to be perennially repeated in ritual (Kapfhammer 2009; Streck 1997). This is a theme found in Baniwa myths and rituals related to initiation also, involving the sacred flutes and trumpets, the bones of the sacrificed deity Kuwai, which suggests the parallel between initiation rites and garden-planting rites. We can now see how the stories line up in a series of parallels: *pariká*, the teacher plant, propitiates the mediation between humans and the primordial world; it cannot be taken by the unprepared because to do so would mix together incompatible categories (e.g. the tapir who is already gluttonous, becomes a ravenous jaguar; a woman's menstrual blood cannot be treated as shaman's snuff; *Kuwai* is the mixture of opposites *par excellence*). Finally, shamans who in real life have 'mastered', or gone beyond, that is, have gone further in their proximity to the deities, come 'close to' becoming 'masters' ('eternal

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masters'), the deities themselves, who 'see' as the creators saw in the beginning.

But why are pepper and tobacco so important as to be included among the first gifts that the creator deities gave to the first ancestors who emerged from the holes of *Hipana* falls? What do they have to do with the well-being of human souls? Tobacco, as we have seen, was a pure gift from *Dzuliferi*, *Nhiãperikuli*'s brother, to him, and, like pepper, is a plant cultivated in home gardens (i.e. both are domesticated). Tobacco promotes the health, well-being, and happiness of the soul. One smokes fresh tobacco and passes around the cigar, saying 'Alira', which means 'thanks'.

Capsicum pepper came into being when *Nhiãperikuli*, as the story goes, was married to the daughter of 'Grandfather piranha', and one day decided to accept his wife's invitation to visit his father-in-law's house in the company of various birds, the allies of *Nhiãperikuli*. As Garnelo astutely observes, the story underscores *Nhiãperikuli*'s ambiguous position, since he feeds off his wife's and father-in-law's kin, that is, fish.

The story not only tells how pepper came to be created by *Nhiãperikuli* who uses it to 'cook' the raw flesh which his father-in-law was going to use to kill him, thereby neutralizing its poison, but also explains the appearance of an illness (*whíokali*, amoebic dysentery) associated with eating raw or undercooked fish, whose secretions can destroy the victim's internal organs. A number of murder attempts occur while the hero is at his father-in-law's house, but *Nhiãperikuli* manages to escape thanks to his skills and shamanic power. The permanent by-products of this episode are pepper and the *whíokali* illness (see Garnelo 2007; Garnelo and Wright 2001).

Pepper is thus like a shield against the potential harm of raw or rotten flesh; it is also like an arrow in killing any animal or human food that may still be 'alive'; and it is like fire in that it 'burns' or cooks raw food.[24]

24. In the lengthy chants to 'bless' food for people undergoing rites of passage, pepper is compared to all of these elements: the arrow, fire, and the shield. It is polysemic in that sense. The Baniwa also have an expression, 'burning sloth fur is a good medicine for pepper', which is a marvelous and pithy statement of what would take many pages to explain. Enough to remember that *Kuwai's* body (that is, his animal-body-projection) is the black sloth and, of course, that *Kuwai* was burned in a huge fire at the end of the first initiation rite. This moment in myth coincides with the moment in the ritual when new initiates are given pepper and manioc bread to eat, signaling that they are fully human beings. Manioc bread, as noted previously, is the body of *Kaali*, likewise burned in a fire.

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Concluding Remarks

This article has discussed the religious symbolism of shamans' snuff and manioc, and to a lesser extent, pepper and tobacco. Its original intention was to include plants that were derived from the bodies of predatory beings of the primordial world as well—such as timbó and curare. Further explorations will look, with equal complexity, at both of these and perhaps others.[25] Thus, the conclusions we draw here represent only a part of the domain of plants and their religious significance.

Pariká and manioc do have one major element in common: both derive from the same deity, *Kaali*, the source of all foods. But they come from two distinct periods of the cosmos: the first, before humanity had been born; the second, when this world had already been formed. Geographically, the main reference points for the two myths are distinct: the Great Tree of *Kaali* was located on a hill of the upper Uaupes River; the hill of *Kaali*'s great plantation is called *Waliiro*, located in the middle of the forest between the Cubate and Içana rivers. The two places may serve as cardinal points in the terrestrial organization of cosmic space.

The story of *pariká* had *Nhiãperikuli* and his tribe of shamans pitted against their animal-'grandfathers', the tapir and others. The story of *Kaali-thayri* focuses on conflict in human relations in the production of gardens and staple food. Predation is not a central theme of either the *pariká* or the manioc stories, except at the moments when the tapir transforms into a jaguar with an insatiable appetite, which is quickly subdued, and, even then, predation is not the key issue, but rather the mixing of two elements that should be kept separate. The knowledge and practice of the *pajés* were only 'tamed' and distributed, according to the story, after the child of the sun was killed and his body floated downriver for every village to receive its share.

Pariká's most important power is to reveal the hidden, the invisible, what is secret in this world, including witchcraft. Regarding the latter, *pariká* is an instrument against which *pajés* may control the actions of witches. In the Other World, it both assists in locating lost souls, and in healing sick people of This World in the Other World first. In short, *pariká* possesses the enormous power to make the *pajé* 'know the world'—to reveal all that is happening in it and what will happen in the future. This does not refer to power in the political sense of hierarchy and domination, but rather the power to act as emissary from the divinities and to guide humans into living in harmony, the much-desired state

25. My hope is that the continuation of this study may be published in a future issue of this journal.

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of well-being and 'happiness'. It is a relation of trust that people invest in the *pajés* that they (the *pajés*) will not 'deceive' them.

Manioc, we might say, is parallel to *pariká* in its social and religious importance. *Pariká* is to the shamans in their intermediary relations between the celestial deities and humans as manioc bread is to the 'masters'/priests, *thayri*, in their immediate relations between the deity of the earth and humans. Whereas the story of *pariká* occurs predominantly on the vertical axis of the cosmos (the link between the Other World and This World), the story of manioc is framed by the horizontal extremities of this earth (where *Kaali*'s plantations were located). This perhaps explains the elaborate rituals of garden-planting which exist at least in the memory of the elders, and why some of the prophets of the past were said to have powers over the gardens. The myth of *Kaali* is similar to stories in other cultures of the divine being who sacrificed himself to his people or is sacrificed by his people, whom he has abandoned or who have rejected him, and the transformation of this god into food for the health and prosperity of the people. *Kaali* was sacrificed in the great fire but left his body in the earth (the very name *Kaali* means 'white earth') to be eaten in the form of manioc bread. In that way, *Kaali* attained immortality, much like the figure of *Kuwai*, the child of the sun who was sacrificed in a huge bonfire and whose body was transformed into the paxiuba palm tree, through which the men initiate their children for all times (see Hill 1993; Journet 1995; Wright 1998) and whose blood is *pariká*. The Kuripako, whom N. Journet worked with, associate the five-leaved manioc plant not only with *Kaali* but also with *Nhiãperikuli* which makes sense of the phrase associated with him, 'our orphan father'. Manioc is a self-generating plant; in the eyes of some it is an orphan, to others, it is immortal.

Returning now to the point mentioned in the Introduction regarding Viveiros de Castro's discussion of 'perspectivism', I wish to raise several questions regarding his instigating article 'Shamanism and Sacrifice' (2002: 59-472). In it, the author discusses the distinctions between shamans, priests, and prophets. Initially, it is important to note that he leaves completely out of the discussion the figure of 'witches' or 'assault sorcerers', which, Whitehead and I have maintained (2004), are religious specialists of equal importance to the others but rarely studied not only because of the secrecy and danger attached to them but also because of the incapacity of Western culture to accept such practices as part of a cultural 'poetic' (see the Introduction to our book for further discussion). If the notion of 'predation by enemy others' is so central to Amazonian cosmologies as De Castro and his students argue, then it is highly pertinent to raise this question and its relation to the plants used in assault

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sorcery. This is crucial to the understanding of both the figures of 'poison owners' among the Baniwa and *Kanaima* practitioners among the Patamona. The 'poison owners' derive their practice from the original figure of *Kuwai* and work predominantly with plant poisons, which are numerous (see my article in Whitehead and Wright 2004).

Viveiros de Castro goes on to discuss the well-known distinction in South American ethnology of horizontal and vertical shamans, both being *ideal types* of shamans, the first exemplified by a sacrificer-victim and the second by the priests (2002: 470). Prophetic movements, for which the Northwest Amazon is a classic area (Wright 2002) were 'always commanded by the horizontal-type shamans' (Viveiros de Castro 2002: 470). He ponders, however, that the horizontal/vertical distinction is not as important as the potential within shamanism to have various 'derivatives'—one that goes in the direction of priestly transformation, the other, prophetic transformation. 'Prophetism would, in this case, be the result of the historical "heating up" of shamanism, while the emergence of the well-defined priestly function would be the result of a political "cooling off", that is, its submission to social power' (2002: 471).

With regard to whether the Northwest Amazon prophets were 'always commanded by the horizontal-type shamans', in my research of the past thirty years on Northwest Amazon prophets, I have found no evidence that would permit making such an assertion.

Secondly, with regard to the potential for derivatives of shamans, either prophets or priests, or even a mixture of both, the model presented by the story of *Kaali* is that of the priest being sacrificed as a consequence of marital disruption; the priest becoming a divinity at the same time his body is absorbed by the earth; and, as though to heal social conflict, the body of the divinity/father is then transformed into life-giving food. It is also worth recalling that the growth of gardens has been one of several central themes of Baniwa prophetic movements. Baniwa mythic models seem to be a complex mixture of shaman/priest/prophet and, beyond that, are coherent with the mythic models of *Pflänzenkulturen*, as defined by Jensen above.

Thirdly, far from being symbols of 'predatory alterity', the model of *Kaali* is that of a *pacifier* who avoids open conflict by taking refuge in inaccessible places. Similarly, the story of *pariká* is of the divinity as *pacifier* of animals/humans-turned-predators. Thus, both *pariká* and manioc bread are *life-giving substances* that the divinities left for humans in order that they may live in peace.

Finally, I raise an alternative interpretation to those acts which might be considered as 'predation' according to Viveiros de Castro's model. The notion of a dangerous 'mixing' of two elements that should be kept

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separate and which produces intolerably ambiguous situations is far closer to the Baniwa understanding of why such situations are dangerous than the supposition that they represent 'predation'. Similarly, the theory of Amerindian perspectivism is considerably more complex when we examine the variety of situations in which perspectives transform because the bodies of subjects actually become Other. Not all is predatory; a great deal has to do with peace.

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